Five possible rounds. Three different businesses.

The first payment buys the MVP. Pre-seed funds validation and early operation; seed follows evidence of paid, repeatable demand.

Round	Development	1 · Focused	2 · Platform	3 · Infrastructure
Pre-seed	V2 + early V3	£300k	£600k	£1m
Seed	V3	£1m	£2m	£3m
Series A	V4–V5	£3m	£6m	£10m
Series B	V6	£7.5m	£15m	£25m
Series C*	V7	£15m	£30m	£50m

* Series C is optional in every route. Route 1 can stop raising after seed or A. Versions describe capability, not an entitlement to a round.

Dimension	1 · Focused	2 · Platform	3 · Infrastructure
Emphasis	Local density and dependable paid work	Governed working relationship and partner services	Reusable product and partner-led distribution
Scale test	Repeat a local cluster economically	Grow volume without proportional review costs	Deploy elsewhere without a bespoke rebuild
Investment case	Efficient acquisition, retention and contribution	Commercial lift from embedded workflows	Recurring partner revenue and proven reuse
Exit review window[1]	After seed/A; years 2–4	Around A/B; years 3–6	Around B/C; years 5–8
Existing stake left after A[2]	51.2% of today’s stake	51.2% of today’s stake	45.0% of today’s stake

[1] Illustrative review horizons from pre-seed close, not sale forecasts. An acquisition can occur at any stage. [2] Before additional option pools, convertibles or other issuances. Each person multiplies their current stake by this factor.

1 · Focused marketplace

Win a concentrated barber market through reliable fulfilment, fair terms and repeat paid usage. Keep the initial operating scope narrow.

Round	New money	New equity	Implied pre / post³	Stake retained²	Illustrative close
Pre-seed	£300k	20%	£1.20m / £1.50m	80.0%	Month 0
Seed	£1m	20%	£4.00m / £5.00m	64.0%	Months 12–18
Series A	£3m	20%	£12.00m / £15.00m	51.2%	Months 24–36
Series B	£7.5m	15%	£42.50m / £50.00m	43.5%	Months 42–60
Series C*	£15m	15%	£85.00m / £100.00m	37.0%	Months 60–84

£4.3m through Series A; £26.8m if every round is taken. £300k over 15 months, retaining 15% as reserve, leaves an average £17k per month for all planned spending. This is a lean pilot budget.

Stage	What the round pays for	Evidence required before progressing
Pre-seed V2 + early V3	Production readiness, agreed V2 tests and a paid local pilot.	Seed case: completed paid jobs, returning shops and barbers, and measured cancellation, recovery and support costs.
Seed V3	Repeat the service in a second local cluster; establish support and acquisition costs.	A case: repeat demand in two clusters; positive contribution per completed job and credible acquisition payback.
Series A V4–V5	Scale the strongest clusters; add only integrations with a demonstrated return.	B case: new clusters reproduce retention and margins without founder-led matching or escalating subsidies.
Series B V6	Enter one new geography or closely related segment after local proof.	C case: the first expansion works after local adaptation and support costs; further capital has a defined use.
Series C* V7	Optional consolidation or wider replication; avoid raising merely to reach V7.	Scale or sale: durable cash generation, clean records and an operating team able to run the business independently.

Acquisition case. A sector software, booking or workforce platform seeking active merchants, supply density and useful distribution. Review a strategic sale after seed or Series A, illustratively years 2–4. A later sale remains possible, but B and C are optional branches here.

Trade-off. Narrower market size may limit venture appetite. If contribution stays negative after fair support costs, more geography compounds the problem. Choose this route if Neil values an earlier sale and capital discipline, or if platform features do not yet produce measurable commercial lift.

² Stake retained means the fraction of today’s holding left after these raises. ³ Arithmetic from assumed cash and dilution, not a valuation opinion. No pool top-ups, convertibles, fees or secondary sales modelled; timing depends on evidence.

2 · Industry operating platform

Use the marketplace to establish a governed working relationship: competence evidence, reliable commitments, fair payment and accountable exception handling.

Round	New money	New equity	Implied pre / post[3]	Stake retained[2]	Illustrative close
Pre-seed	£600k	20%	£2.40m / £3.00m	80.0%	Month 0
Seed	£2m	20%	£8.00m / £10.00m	64.0%	Months 12–18
Series A	£6m	20%	£24.00m / £30.00m	51.2%	Months 24–36
Series B	£15m	20%	£60.00m / £75.00m	41.0%	Months 42–60
Series C*	£30m	15%	£170.00m / £200.00m	34.8%	Months 60–84

£8.6m through Series A; £53.6m if every round is taken. £600k over 18 months, retaining 15% as reserve, leaves an average £28.3k per month for all planned spending. Scope and staffing must fit that limit.

Stage	What the round pays for	Evidence required before progressing
Pre-seed V2 + early V3	V2 testing, launch operations and a paid pilot that measures the cost and benefit of governance.	Seed case: recurring paid usage; auditable disputes and money states; review cost per job and customer outcomes measured.
Seed V3	Repeat V3 operation; establish customer willingness to pay and validate intelligence against a simpler baseline.	A case: improved retention, fulfilment or support efficiency attributable to the added capabilities; margins survive their costs.
Series A V4–V5	V4 partner services and V5 growth: payment integration, selected earnings options and proven workflow automation.	B case: signed provider economics, reliable integrations, repeatable customer acquisition and controls that function at higher volume.
Series B V6	V6 entry into selected markets, with local partners and repeatable implementation.	C case: a second deployment reproduces the economics; implementation, localisation and partner concentration are understood.
Series C* V7	Optional V7 replication or acquisitions where operating evidence supports the spend.	Scale or sale: transferable IP and contracts, independently run operations, durable net revenue and a clear integration case.

Acquisition case. Vertical software, workforce or payments platforms seeking embedded operating workflows, distribution and evidenced transaction economics. An early capability sale is possible after seed. The stronger operating-business sale thesis is around Series A/B, illustratively years 3–6.

Trade-off. Governance can become a labour-intensive service. Protection can create losses. If review, claims and integration costs outrun retained revenue, the platform thesis weakens. This is the strongest working case from today’s discussion, conditional on proof. Keep the option to stay focused if added complexity does not earn its cost.

[2] Stake retained means the fraction of today’s holding left after these raises. [3] Arithmetic from assumed cash and dilution, not a valuation opinion. No pool top-ups, convertibles, fees or secondary sales modelled; timing depends on evidence.

3 · Replicable infrastructure

Prove the barber use case, then sell a reusable operating layer through partners into selected countries or adjacent sectors. Licensing or API revenue is a proposed new model.

Round	New money	New equity	Implied pre / post[3]	Stake retained[2]	Illustrative close
Pre-seed	£1m	25%	£3.00m / £4.00m	75.0%	Month 0
Seed	£3m	25%	£9.00m / £12.00m	56.2%	Months 12–18
Series A	£10m	20%	£40.00m / £50.00m	45.0%	Months 24–36
Series B	£25m	20%	£100.00m / £125.00m	36.0%	Months 42–60
Series C*	£50m	15%	£283.33m / £333.33m	30.6%	Months 60–84

£14m through Series A; £89m if every round is taken. £1m over 18 months, retaining 15% as reserve, leaves an average £47.2k per month for all planned spending. £1.5–2m is a stretch alternative only with a costed team and milestones.

Stage	What the round pays for	Evidence required before progressing
Pre-seed V2 + early V3	Validate the barber service plus reusable architecture, evidence rights and demand from potential distribution partners.	Seed case: barber pilot evidence and credible partner demand; code and data rights support the intended reuse.
Seed V3	Prove the first repeatable deployment; test paid partner demand without expanding across sectors prematurely.	A case: external willingness to pay for the operating layer; clear separation of reusable product and bespoke services.
Series A V4–V5	Productise integrations, licensing and implementation; deliver a second independently operated deployment.	B case: a second paid deployment with quantified reuse, implementation time, support load and gross margin.
Series B V6	Enter selected countries or sectors through partners; build enterprise support and delivery capacity.	C case: several independent deployments retain customers and margins after local standards, permissions and integration costs.
Series C* V7	Optional broad replication, larger partnerships or acquisitions after the model transfers economically.	Scale or sale: material recurring platform revenue, low dependency on any one partner and a transferable platform business.

Acquisition case. A larger workforce, vertical software, payments or technology group seeking reusable capabilities and partner distribution. A technology sale can occur earlier, but the full infrastructure thesis is more credibly reviewed around B/C, illustratively years 5–8.

Trade-off. Highest execution and financing exposure. Bespoke deployments can turn apparent software scale into consultancy; larger rounds also raise the required exit outcome. Advance to this route only after Route 2 proves transferability and partner demand. The present discussion alone does not justify infrastructure pricing.

[2] Stake retained means the fraction of today’s holding left after these raises. [3] Arithmetic from assumed cash and dilution, not a valuation opinion. No pool top-ups, convertibles, fees or secondary sales modelled; timing depends on evidence.

The proof that makes a route fundable

The stronger story must earn its complexity. These are proposed evidence gates, with thresholds to be agreed before the pilot.

What changed in today’s thesis

Reciprocal obligations and competence. Better matches and reliability can drive repeat use. Test completed-job rate, repeat usage and appeal outcomes; keep review costs in the margin.

Intelligence inside the workflow. Evidence can improve matching and case handling. Compare it with a simpler baseline; measure errors, overrides and time saved. Prompts alone do not establish a moat.

Payments, protection and earnings. Useful services may deepen retention. Count only contracted net revenue; include processing, claims and support. Identify the payer for every guarantee.

Replication and acquisition readiness. Reusable workflows can widen the buyer case. Test a second deployment; document code ownership, data permissions, contracts and founder dependencies.

Final MVP / V2 testing

01. Booking: competence, conditions, terms and mutual acceptance.

02. Competence challenge: standard, evidence and review reasons.

03. Barber absence: contact, replacement, refund and consequences.

04. Shop cancellation: fair response and a named protection funder.

05. Disputed payment: evidence, reply, appeal and settlement.

06. Genuine emergency: accountable exception and recorded reasons.

07. Earnings/protection: exploratory unless adopted; test terms and downside.

08. System error: trace, authorised repair, notification and retest.

Release proposal: all adopted critical scenarios pass; no unresolved critical defect. Preserve build/rule versions, money states, support time and results. Distinguish simulation, provider tests and live use.

Exit discipline. New primary funding belongs to the company. Personal liquidity requires a separately agreed secondary sale or acquisition. Actual proceeds depend on debt, preferences, consent rights, deal structure and tax. Raising again should improve expected net proceeds enough to justify dilution, time and execution risk. [5]

Market calibration. Carta’s US Q2 2026 reference medians are 19.4% dilution at seed and 18.7% at A; they do not price this UK business. UK seed deal count fell 27% in 2025. Fresha’s 2026 growth investment and Booksy’s 2021 Genbook purchase support the adjacent-sector logic. Their scale and business models differ from Barber Republic. [1–4]

Before choosing the raise. Confirm a monthly cash plan, current ownership and option commitments, pricing and contribution assumptions, and Neil’s preferred exit horizon and minimum cash outcome. The scenarios model zero opening cash and no operating receipts when sizing pre-seed spending capacity.

Dilution hurdle. After a round selling 20%, comparable distributable exit proceeds must rise 25% just to preserve an existing holder’s gross payout. This arithmetic excludes preferences, debt, tax, elapsed time and changes in execution risk.

1 · Carta, Q2 2026 seed and A benchmarks
2 · British Business Bank, Equity Tracker, 2 July 2026
3 · Fresha, KKR growth investment, 21 May 2026
4 · Booksy, acquisition of Genbook, 7 September 2021
5 · Carta, liquidation preferences